

English Grammar — Mock Examination

Bachillerato · Centro Educativo Británico S21 · Paper 1: Grammar in Use

Name: _____

Date: _____

TIME ALLOWED: 50 MINUTES. Answer all questions in the spaces provided.

You are assessed on the **ACCURACY OF YOUR EXPLANATIONS**, not merely correct answers. For every item, explain the grammar: name the tense/aspect or structure and say precisely *why* it is used. Full marks require complete reasoning and, where asked, your own examples.

Section A — Sentence Analysis

Q1. *Analyse the following sentence.*

| By the time the firefighters arrived, the building had already collapsed.

Explain why the past perfect is used here and what would change if both verbs were past simple.

Q2. *Analyse the following sentence.*

| If I had listened to my parents, I wouldn't be in this mess now.

Identify the type of conditional and explain why each clause uses the form it does.

Q3. *Analyse the following sentence.*

| The new vaccine is being tested on volunteers and is expected to be approved next year.

Explain the two passive constructions and why the passive is appropriate here.

Q4. *Analyse the following sentence.*

| She can't have forgotten the meeting; she must have been stuck in traffic.

Explain both modal structures, the certainty each expresses, and why these are past forms.

Q5. *Analyse the following sentence.*

| Reported version: She told me she had been waiting there since the previous day.

Reconstruct the likely direct speech and explain every change the backshift caused.

Section B — Choose and Justify

Q6. Choose the best option and justify it: "I can't believe it — someone ____ my bike!"

- A. stole
- B. has stolen
- C. had stolen
- D. was stealing

Say why your choice is right AND why each other option is wrong.

Q7. Choose and justify: "Honestly, you ____ bothered cooking — we'd already eaten."

- A. didn't need to
- B. needn't have
- C. mustn't have
- D. shouldn't

Justify your choice and explain the meaning difference with the closest distractor.

Section C — Explain the Rule

Q8.

Explain how conditional inversion works and when you would use it. Give examples for the first, second and third conditionals.

Cover the mechanism, the register/effect, and one inverted example per conditional type.

Marking Key — Model Answers & Checklists

Q1. Analysis.

arrived — past simple: a completed past event, the reference point of the narrative.

had already collapsed — past perfect ('had + participle'). It's used to show this event happened **before** the arrival — the 'past-before-the-past'. 'By the time' sets up two past events, and the past perfect orders them so the collapse is clearly earlier.

'already' reinforces 'before that point'.

If both were past simple ('When the firefighters arrived, the building collapsed') the natural reading flips: the collapse would seem to happen **at or just after** their arrival, not before it. So the past perfect isn't decorative here — it changes the meaning by fixing the sequence.

Award marks for: Identifies 'arrived' as past simple (the reference point); Identifies 'had collapsed' as past perfect = past-before-past; Explains the past perfect orders the two events (collapse before arrival); Notes 'by the time'/'already' support the earlier-event reading; Explains that two past simples would change the sequence/meaning.

Q2. Analysis.

This is a **mixed conditional**: a **past condition** with a **present result**.

If-clause: 'had listened' — past perfect. It refers to an unreal past action (I did NOT listen), which is the third-conditional form. The past perfect marks both the past time and the unreality.

Result clause: 'wouldn't be ... now' — 'would + base' (not 'would have + participle'). This is the second-conditional result form, used because the consequence is in the **present** — signalled explicitly by **'now'**.

So the sentence mixes the past 'if' of the third conditional with the present 'result' of the second, precisely because the cause is past but its effect is current. Note also that there is no 'would' in the if-clause — that would be an error.

Award marks for: Names it a mixed conditional (past condition / present result); Identifies 'had listened' as past perfect = unreal past; Identifies 'wouldn't be' as 'would + base' for a present result; Pinpoints 'now' as the signal that the result is present; Notes the 'no would in the if-clause' rule is respected.

Q3. Analysis.

is being tested — present continuous passive (is/are being + past participle). The original active idea ('researchers are testing the vaccine') is turned passive to **focus on the vaccine**, not the unnamed researchers — typical of scientific/impersonal register. The continuous shows it's in progress now.

is expected to be approved — two layers: (1) **is expected** is an impersonal reporting passive ('people expect...') that distances the claim from any source; (2) **to be approved** is a passive infinitive (to be + participle), again foregrounding the vaccine over whoever approves it.

Why passive: the agents (researchers, regulators) are unknown or irrelevant, and the passive gives the formal, objective tone expected in this kind of writing.

Award marks for: Identifies 'is being tested' as present continuous passive (is/are being + participle); Explains the focus shifts to the vaccine / agent is irrelevant; Identifies 'is expected' as an impersonal reporting passive; Identifies 'to be approved' as a passive infinitive; States WHY the passive is used here (focus / formal-impersonal tone).

Q4. Analysis.

Both are **modals of deduction about the past**, formed with **modal + have + participle**.

can't have forgotten — a **confident negative** deduction: the speaker is sure she did NOT forget. Note: for past negative certainty we use 'can't have', never 'mustn't have' (which would mean prohibition). 'forgotten' is the past participle inside the structure.

must have been stuck — a **confident positive** deduction: given the evidence, the speaker concludes this is what happened. 'must have been' = the past of deductive 'must'.

They're past forms ('have + participle') because the speaker is reasoning about events that have **already happened**, not a present state.

Award marks for: Identifies both as past modals of deduction (modal + have + participle); Explains 'can't have' = confident negative deduction (not mustn't); Explains 'must have' = confident positive deduction; Notes the certainty level each modal encodes; Explains the 'have + participle' makes them refer to the past.

Q5. Analysis.

Likely original: "**I have been waiting here since yesterday,**" she said (to me).

Changes:

- **told me** — the reporting verb 'tell' takes a person object ('me'). If 'say' were used it would be 'said to me' or just 'said'.
- **she / I** — pronoun shift to the reporter's viewpoint.
- **had been waiting** ← **have been waiting** — present perfect continuous backshifts to past perfect continuous.
- **there** ← **here** — place word shifts away from the speaker's location.
- **the previous day** ← **yesterday** — time word shifts to the reported viewpoint ('yesterday' → 'the previous/day before').

Award marks for: Reconstructs a plausible direct-speech original; Explains 'told me' needs a person object (say vs. tell); Explains the pronoun shift (I → she); Explains present perfect continuous → past perfect continuous; Explains here→there and yesterday→the previous day.

Q6. Correct answer: B.

Correct: 'has stolen' (present perfect). There's no finished-time adverbial, and the action's **result is relevant now** ('I can't believe it' — the bike is gone at this moment). Present perfect = past action with present relevance. That's the justification.

'stole' (past simple) — would need finished time ('stole it yesterday') and would cut the link to now; it sounds like a detached report, not a present discovery.

'had stolen' (past perfect) — needs a *second, later* past event to be 'before'. There's no such anchor here, so the past perfect is stranded.

'was stealing' (past continuous) — describes an action in progress in the past ('while I was watching, someone was stealing it'); it doesn't fit a completed discovery with present impact.

Award marks for: Picks 'has stolen' and names it present perfect; Justifies it by present relevance / no finished-time adverbial; Rejects 'stole': needs finished time, breaks the link to now; Rejects 'had stolen': no later past event for it to precede; Rejects 'was stealing': that's an in-progress past action, not a result.

Q7. Correct answer: B.

Correct: 'needn't have' (needn't have bothered). The cooking **did happen**, but it turned out to be unnecessary ('we'd already eaten'). 'needn't have + participle' is precisely 'you did it, but you didn't need to'.

Closest distractor — 'didn't need to': this normally implies the action *wasn't necessary and so wasn't done* ('I didn't need to cook, so I ordered in'). Here the cooking clearly happened, so 'needn't have' is the accurate choice — this is the classic contrast the exam tests.

'mustn't have' isn't used for this meaning (it's not standard for regret/necessity), and **'shouldn't'** alone ('you shouldn't cook') would wrongly refer to a general/present prohibition, not a past unnecessary action.

Award marks for: Picks 'needn't have'; Explains it = the action was done but turned out unnecessary; Contrasts with 'didn't need to' = wasn't necessary (and usually not done); Rejects 'mustn't have' as not used for this meaning; Rejects 'shouldn't' as wrong time/meaning.

Q8. Explanation.

What it is: formal English can drop 'if' and invert the subject with an auxiliary, producing a more formal/literary conditional.

Mechanism: remove 'if'; bring the auxiliary in front of the subject. If there's no auxiliary, use 'should' (1st), 'were' (2nd), or 'had' (3rd).

- **First:** 'If you need help...' → **Should you need** help, call me.
- **Second:** 'If I were rich...' → **Were I** rich, I'd travel.
- **Third:** 'If I had known...' → **Had I known**, I'd have helped.

When to use it: in formal writing, polite offers, and to vary style. The meaning is unchanged; only the register rises — which is exactly why it's prized in formal exam writing.

Award marks for: States the mechanism: drop 'if', auxiliary before subject; Gives the right auxiliary per type (should / were / had); Provides a correct inverted example for the first conditional; Provides correct inverted examples for second and third; Explains the effect = raised formality, same meaning.